



Google News offers news from 4,500 sources

latest happenings in the Linux community, the latest trends in fashion or just read messages from user groups—tastes vary, and one person's pleasure is another's poison. Here's where a desktop aggregator comes in to save us from the cacophony of garbled information that the Internet is. A desktop aggregator sets you free by controlling your dosage of information to exactly what you want and need.

Whatever your poison; chances are there is someone out there publishing it in XML format or running a blog on it. Even if there isn't, you can build your own site, and with a few lines of code, syndicate information from other sites for your areas of interest on to your Web page.

How does it work for me?

Personalising your syndication requirements is easy with software such as AmphetaDesk, Beaver and Syndirella that deliver news to you from popular news sites, or other sites you choose to subscribe to. These software, known as news aggregators, can deliver a plethora of the latest news from all around the world to your desktop, keeping you as informed as a news anchor for the BBC. What type of information, and how much information you get is limited only by your imagination, your Internet connection speed and the capacity of your hard drive.

How to?

First things first: You need to choose the type of aggregator that you are comfortable with. There are two basic types—Web page type and the three-pane type aggregators. They are named according to the way they display the news, after they update and collate the data that you have opted to subscribe to. This is the only noticeable difference between the two types, and mail client users will probably feel more comfortable with the Three pane type.

For those who have never used aggregators before, the toughest part is learning about subscriptions. In order to receive news updates on your choice of subjects, you have to find the appropriate XML links. Most sites that provide content in XML or RSS format, advertise the fact with little orange XML Buttons. If you copy the link associated with this button, and subscribe using your aggregator, you will receive the latest updates from that site. You might face some slight problems initially when trying to find these links, or while subscribing to them, but a few trial runs later, you will be well-versed in the nuances of blog searching.

Most aggregators have a default list of general news links—ranging from world news and sports, to the latest on the XML front and developer news. They also offer links to various Web sites such as popular blogs. Look through the list that is displayed on your aggregator's Web site and chances are you will find what you are looking for right there instead of searching for it on the Net. However, if you still want to search for content, you should look out for XML buttons on the sites you visit.

Once you've zeroed in on the stuff you want to keep track of, all you have to do is subscribe to it via any Web page display aggregator such as AmphetaDesk. Just run the installer, extract to a folder location on your hard disk, double-click on the .exe file and wait for it to update itself. When AmphetaDesk is updated, it will open a locally hosted Web page, with the latest versions of the default subscriptions. Now you are free to mould the Web page as per your preferences, and add or delete subscriptions. To add subscriptions, click on Add a Channel and choose from the list of the thousands of popular feeds that are displayed alphabetically, or add a link to a known Web address.

Once you have decided on your



AmphetaDesk's Web page display style

Aggregators Ahoy!

Some aggregators are Web-based, or can send news feeds and updates via e-mail. Others are Web page display or three-pane display types.

Some other popular aggregators are:

Peerkat: A Web page display type aggregator, that can be found at <http://www.oreillynet.com/~rael/lang/python/peerkat/>

Beaver: A popular three-pane display aggregator, which can be download at <http://www31.brinkster.com/toolmaker/beaver.htm>

FeedReader: Another three-pane display type of aggregator, which can be downloaded from www.feedreader.com

News Is Free is a Web-based aggregator, that allows you to build a personal Web page with feeds of your choice. www.newsisfree.com

Rss2email: A tool for Linux users that can send news and updates from the feeds you chose, to your e-mail account. However, this is a script that has to be run on a Unix based server that has 24/7 connectivity—get it at <http://www.w3.org/2002/09/rss2email/>



The AmphetaDesk My Settings page

choice of subscriptions, click on My Settings and personalise the way AmphetaDesk works. Changing the refresh rate to the minimum—once an hour is probably wise for those who want fast updates and near real-time information. Once you have checked all the settings and subscribed to your choice of links, just sit back and relax, and watch the information flow into your lap.

Three-pane display aggregators such as Syndirella, run on Microsoft's .NET platform. Hence, if you don't have .NET installed, you can download the 20 MB file from www.microsoft.com or by using Windows Update. Most software have